Boris Ayala

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Areas of Specialization

Epistemology
Philosophy of Language
Metaphysics

Areas of Competence

Philosophy of Mind
Ethics
Logic

Education

CUNY Graduate Center, PhD in Philosophy, February 2026

Dissertation: *Systems Epistemology*
Committee: Muhammad Ali Khalidi (supervisor)
Stephen Hetherington (external member)
Graham Priest
Lisa Warenski

Dissertation Summary: I advance an account of knowledge holding that to know a fact one must grasp it together with a larger slice of reality that contains it. This slice consists of a system of facts, which we represent through a system of true beliefs (STB). An STB, in turn, contains the relations of support necessary for justification. By shifting our attention from the credentials of an individual belief to the structural features of a set of beliefs, the approach offers a new way to understand knowledge, justification, and epistemic regress. First, I argue that the structure of knowledge reflects the structure of the system of facts it corresponds with. And since facts do not relate to each other by inference, the structure of knowledge is not inferential either. Second, I show that embedment in an STB is a kind of justification and argue that, unlike foundationalism and coherentism, it can explain various features of our justificatory practices. Third, I show that epistemic regress is a problem only if justification is a property that is transmitted from an originating source. I argue that embedment defangs regress because it is an emergent property that is not transmissible and has no originating source.

Research Manuscripts

Truth's Content (under review)
I argue that, contrary to common thought, truth predications have semantic content and that we can pinpoint what this content amounts to. I present two cases where an individual rationally and sensibly believes that *p* is true but does not believe that p. This can happen only if the two propositions have different content. Further, since content eliminates worlds that do not conform with it, and "*p*" and "<*p*> is true" differ in terms of their world-eliminating behavior, it follows that the two propositions have different content.

Frege's Puzzle is Not a Semantic Puzzle
I argue that it is a mistake to read Frege's Puzzle as posing a semantic problem. Its central question is not how referentially equivalent statements manage to mean different things, but rather how they manage to convey different information. In this paper I show that the puzzle arises independently of semantic interpretation, that cognitive value is not a semantic property, and that semantic factors have no effect on the puzzle's main variable.

Frege's Puzzle is Syntactic: Syntax Encodes Extra-Semantic Information
This paper offers a syntactic solution to Frege's Puzzle. Its key feature is the individuation of *uninterpreted* names. Statements like "a=b" convey more information than statements like "a=a" simply because of their form, and the semantic values of "a" and "b" are of no relevance to the statements' ability to carry information. In this paper I show how syntax encodes the relevant kind of information and how syntactic variation affects informativeness.

Teaching Experience

Hunter College
Introduction to Logic and the Scientific Method, fall 2026
Introduction to Philosophy, spring 2026
Knowledge and Reality, fall 2022 and spring 2023
(Instructor of record for all courses listed)

College of Staten Island
Introduction to Logic and Science, multiple semesters, 2017–2019
Introduction to Ethics, fall 2016
Writing Across the Curriculum (writing fellow): fall 2019 and spring 2020
(Instructor of record for all courses listed except WAC)

Presentations

- Truth's Content. Symposium paper, 2027 Eastern APA meeting

Graduate Coursework

- Belief, Eric Mandelbaum
- Consciousness, David Rosenthal and Tony Ro
- Epistemology, Richard Foley
- Ethics, Steven Ross
- History of the Mind, Peter Godfrey-Smith
- Kant's Critique of Pure Reason, Angelica Nuzzo
- Language, Stephen Neale
- Logic, Lisa Warenski
- Meaning and Normativity, Paul Boghossian and Paul Horwich

- Morality, Subjectivity and Objectivity, Miranda Fricker
- Naturalized Metaphysics, Michael Devitt
- Perception, Ned Block and Eric Mandelbaum
- Physicalism, David Papineau
- Plato's Republic, Iakovos Vasiliou
- Pragmatism, Peter Godfrey-Smith
- Reference and Experimental Philosophy, Michael Devitt

Other Education

NYU School of Law, JD
Law Review, Petrie Scholar, Hearst Scholar, Dean's Merit Scholarship
Study abroad: Université de Paris II, Panthéon-Assas
Service: Taught paralegal certification courses at local prisons

Dartmouth College, BA with honors, Government
Study abroad: London School of Economics
Université de Toulouse
Pontificia Universidad Católica del Perú
Service: Taught math and English courses at local prisons

Other Professional Experience

While employed by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), I managed maternal health and primary education projects in Zambia, Rwanda, and India.

References

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Stephen Hetherington (external committee member)
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Lisa Warenski (committee member)
Affiliated Professor, CUNY Graduate Center
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Sandra Shapshay (teaching reference)
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